



# Influencer relations: Establishing the concept and process for public relations

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## ABSTRACT

Despite the recent influx of studies examining the role of influencers in a campaign, most studies examine influencer marketing, leaving the public relations approach to influencers underdeveloped. Through in-depth interviews with professionals who work with influencers, this study establishes the concept and process of influencer relations. Results illustrate key relational and dialogic factors of influencer relations. This study also provides a set of best practices for working with influencers in public relations.

## 1. Introduction

Influencers have been a growing force in research and practice, especially in marketing (Ye, Hudders et al., 2021). Though influencers have been examined in public relations literature, the dominant consideration in research on influencers has been developed in the realm of influencer marketing, whereby companies employ influencers to carry their message to social media audiences, while sidestepping the sentiment that the message is an advertisement and tapping into the credibility of the influencer (Bakker, 2018; Hudders et al., 2021). Despite the work that has been done to understand and develop the strategic use of influencers, factors of effectiveness remain underdeveloped (Martinez-Lopez et al., 2020).

Given the emphasis on social media in public relations research and practice (Wang et al., 2021), this study seeks to establish a public relations orientation to working with influencers. Through in-depth interviews with 14 professionals who work with influencers, this study defines influencer relations as a separate but integrated function with influencer marketing and proposes factors that determine success. Best practices are also provided.

## 2. Literature review

Social media influencers (hereafter referred to as SMIs or Influencers) are conceptualized as individuals who shape attitudes through blogs, tweets, and other social media updates (Freberg et al., 2011), and

who engage large follower bases through a “homophilous connection of shared social demographics” (Davies & Hobbs, 2020, p. 2) with narration of their personal life and activities (Archer, 2019). SMIs represent a new category of opinion leaders, with a position somewhere between celebrities and friends (Blanche et al., 2021).

Successful SMIs influencers effectively combine expertise, authenticity, and intimacy to build a close bond with their followers (Enke & Borchers, 2019; Hudders et al., 2021). Influencers may fulfill promotional roles previously filled by agencies, the media, and even opinion leaders as they offer the opportunity to connect with publics who might not normally interact with an organization (Davies & Hobbs, 2020; Enke & Borchers, 2019). However, SMIs are considered distinct from other media outlets because of their voice of authority and trust among their communities (Charlton & Cornwell, 2019; Childers et al., 2019; Himelboim & Golan, 2019; Lou & Yuan, 2019), built through a sense of intimacy and parasocial relationship with their followers (Davies & Hobbs, 2020) that enables them to have a unique impact on other social media users (Hudders, et al., 2021).

In an environment of diminished attention to online promotion (Galloway, 2017; Yang & Saffer, 2020) influencers can build attention for organizations because of their authenticity, expertise, and trust among followers (Lou, 2022; Khamis et al., 2017; Kim et al., 2021; Reinikainen et al., 2020). Influencer roles run the gamut from community advocate to brand partner (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017) and become an organizational asset through their ability to engage specific and even niche audiences (Borchers, 2019; Borchers & Enke, 2021).

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Managing the connection between influencer and organization is underexplored (Borchers & Enke, 2021). Perhaps the difficulty of developing insights on influencers for research and practice is the various terms used to refer to such work. Marketing literature uses the term influencer marketing. Public relations literature uses influencer relations. Enke and Borchers (2019) use the term “strategic influencer communication” to encompass both influencer marketing and influencer relations, defining it as “the purposeful use of communication by organizations or social media influencers in which social media influencers are addressed or perform activities with strategic significance to organizational goals” (p. 271). Therefore, to establish the concept of influencer relations requires first to differentiate the terms.

## 2.1. Influencer marketing

Most of the research examines influencers in terms of influencer marketing (Borchers & Enke, 2021), which, as a form of native or embedded advertising, seeks to tap the authenticity of influencers for brand awareness and commercial gain (Campbell & Farrell, 2020; Delbaere et al., 2021; Hudders et al., 2021; Hughes et al., 2019). Defined as “a process of digital marketing where opinion leaders (influencers) are identified and then integrated into a brand’s brand communication on social media platforms” (Bakker, 2018, p. 80), influencer marketing is considered a “covert marketing tactic” (Ye et al., 2021) that works on the notion that an influencer-endorsed message is more effective because consumers may not perceive their content as advertising (Hudders et al., 2021). This enables companies to tap into the trust that consumers put in influencers as independent experts (Vangelov, 2019). An example of influencer marketing is the 2021 Dunkin’ campaign in the United States engaging TikTok influencer Charli D’Amelio to create sponsored content for the brand under the hashtag #CharliXDunkinContest along with the launch of a new drink, named “the Charli”.

Influencer marketing tends to work based on pay-to-play arrangements that ensure a positive endorsement (Howlett et al., 2021), with some scholars claiming that monetization differentiates an influencer from a popular social media user (Abidin, 2015). Studies show that influencers increasingly prefer to be compensated, especially considering the trend for SMIs to use social media as a career (Archer & Harrigan, 2016) and the trend for marketers to select SMIs based on product and service relevance (Ye et al., 2021). As such, influencer marketing is often equated with celebrity endorsement (Jahnke, 2018), though SMIs maintain authenticity and personal connections that celebrities may not (Vangelov, 2019).

Despite the expansion of influencer marketing research over the past few years (Ye et al., 2021), there is still a dearth of insights on ensuring influencer marketing effectiveness (Martinez-Lopez et al., 2020). Though some studies have identified influencer type, source credibility, and content characteristics as factors of influencer marketing success (Hughes et al., 2019), companies also resort to trial and error (Hudders et al., 2021).

## 2.2. Influencer relations

With influencers firmly planted as “stakeholders who are now in the PR purview” (Archer, 2019), influencer relations position the public relations professional as “the liaison between a company and those considered to be influencers within the social media community” (Boone et al., 2016, p.112). Influencer relations falls within the public relations spectrum (Gallagher, 2021), and the function has been considered a tool under the umbrella of strategic influencer communication, in which social media influencers “perform activities with strategic significance to organizational goals” and practitioners “seek long-term effects through long-term collaboration” (Borchers & Enke, 2021, p. 2, 11). In real-world examples of influencer relations, an organization or brand provides free product to an influencer to demonstrate or discuss, like US craft brand Fiskars providing craft influencer The House that Lars Built

product to use in a crafting project.

Scholars claim working with influencers is distinct from other traditional outlets (i.e., journalists, creative agencies, opinion leaders) (Borchers & Enke, 2021). From a public relations perspective, this distinctiveness may present itself in considerations of risk and control, ethics, the question of compensation, and relationship management.

### 2.2.1. Risk and control

Influencers can attract reputation-damaging publicity (Hudders et al., 2021), especially if they “go rogue” (Davies & Hobbs, 2020, p. 6). Selecting an influencer with good fit can be a challenge, especially since selection processes differ from traditional content providers (Borchers & Enke, 2021). Therefore, granting the SMI the creative freedom needed is a significant risk.

Research shows dissatisfaction among practitioners regarding controlling influencer behavior and balancing power (Archer, 2019; Borchers & Enke, 2021). This may be because SMIs demand higher levels of control than other content providers to maintain authenticity (Borchers & Enke, 2021). Influencers need control because of their sense of responsibility to their content (Archer, 2019), and some scholars doubt the possibility to control SMIs because of their position on social media (Archer & Harrigan, 2016). Davies and Hobbs (2020) warned against making SMIs “controlled spokespeople with established and attentive audiences” for brand messaging (p. 5). To these points, few studies have examined risk and control in working with influencers, as evidenced in recent literature reviews (Hudders et al., 2021), prompting Borchers and Enke (2021) to call for more research on balancing control.

### 2.2.2. Influencer ethics

There is an immersion of commercial interests into the social media sphere that threatens to turn the potential democratizing force of social media into a playground of corporate interests as practitioners “plunder the space for profit” (Archer, 2019, p. 160). Influencer relations may be considered part and parcel of that plunder, yielding the need to examine the “sense of ethics and ethical expectations” between organization and influencer (Borchers & Enke, 2021, p. 12). This examination includes the consideration that scholars cannot simply “transfer the routines from more traditional communication functions to influencer communication” (Borchers & Enke, 2021, p. 12).

The problem? Social media may predispose practitioners to “persuasive strategies and covert activities that lack transparency and are inconsistent with the ethical ideals of best practice” (Davies & Hobbs, 2020, p. 1). And this is despite calls to avoid covert tactics and consider the limited experience of popular social media users in the promotional arena (Smith, 2011). Recent studies show transparency and disclosure are secondary to commercial objectives for practitioners (Davies & Hobbs, 2020). This concern extends to an influencer’s followers, who may be vulnerable to covert marketing (Archers, 2019)—a concern that extends to influencers who may “misuse resource power of an organization” to gain follower trust (Davies & Hobbs, 2020, p. 2).

Though the onus may be on the influencer to disclose sponsorships (Hudders et al., 2021), those efforts may be stymied by the tendency for transparency to negatively affect purchase intentions (Hudders et al., 2021). In the face of recent updates to regulatory guidelines, much work remains to establish practical ethical scenarios in research (Davies & Hobbs, 2020). Recent studies have begun to establish an ethical orientation to working with influencers, including a focus on authenticity and transparency as hallmarks of ethics (Borchers & Enke, 2022; Wellman et al., 2020). The current study continues this focus on ethics.

### 2.2.3. The question of compensation

Conceptualizing blogger relations, Smith (2011) argues that its effectiveness is built on establishing win-win situations, a consideration which is evident in the trend to compensate influencers either monetarily or non-monetarily (Archer, 2019; Borchers & Enke, 2021). Financial compensation as a standard for SMIs (Campbell & Farrell,

2020) renders payment a necessary discussion for developing public relations theory (Archer & Harrigan, 2016).

Monetary compensation is often justified because of the cost effectiveness and efficiency of using influencers to reach “highly engaged and very specific audiences” (Borchers & Enke, 2021, p. 337). Studies show that monetary compensation is a significant motivation for SMIs (Archer, 2019; Archer & Harrigan, 2016; Borchers & Enke, 2022). For a function that usually favors serving the public interest over paid media, Davies and Hobbs contend: “Just as a public relations practitioner is a paid agent with a vested interest... [SMIs can] service the public, provided practitioners agree to use them as agents to facilitate genuine dialogue rather than as covert corporate propagandists” (p. 5). Compensation not only helps SMIs “monetize their status as micro-celebrities” (Davies & Hobbs, p. 1), it is also a hallmark of ethical practitioner-influencer interaction (Borchers & Enke, 2022). Archer and Harrigan (2016) argue, “The mask of relationship building in the social media age needs to be removed and the importance of payment to bloggers needs to be acknowledge for the theories of PR to develop” (p. 68).

#### 2.2.4. Relationships in PR

With studies raising concerns about covert marketing practices (Davies & Hobbs, 2020), influencer relations may be differentiated by a focus on relationships. The standard in public relations literature is to examine the relationship between stakeholder and organization (Sha, 2019), which comprises the extent to which the actions of either party “impact the economic, social, cultural, or political wellbeing of the other” (Ledingham & Bruning, 1998, p. 62). Relationships hinge on mutual benefit, commitment, trust, satisfaction, and control mutuality (Grunig & Huang, 2000; Hon & Grunig, 1999). Furthermore, relationship quality influences sense of belonging and willingness to advocate for an organization (Lee, 2019; Pang et al., 2016). Both relate directly to working with influencers.

Public relations research emphasizes a dialogic approach to relationships whereby organizations adapt to stakeholder needs, prioritize self-worth, and communicate openly (Kent & Taylor, 2016; Peng et al., 2018). Consensus on distribution of power is a significant consideration (Ferguson, 2018) and includes inclusiveness and involving stakeholder input on decision-making (Kent, 2013). In this way, public relations professionals work with stakeholder interest in an organization’s activities, creating community and ensuring benefit for stakeholders in the relationship (Kent, 2013).

Studies on influencers signal the importance of relationships—not only between practitioner and influencer, but also between influencer and follower (Borchers & Enke, 2021). However, some argue that the distinctive nature of influencer relations also requires a new approach to building relationships (Archer & Harrigan, 2016). This new approach may relate to the way influencer relations outsource relationship cultivation and network building (Davies & Hobbs, 2020), as influencers serve as mediators, or “brokers for stakeholder relationships, dialogue, trust, and authenticity” (Borchers & Enke, 2021, p. 10). This relationship outsourcing is denounced as an advertising-led model (Borchers & Enke, 2021).

With the goal of influencer relations to “ensure long-term effects through long-term collaboration” (Borchers & Enke, 2021, p. 10), the need remains to understand how to build successful relationships with influencers. The purpose of this study is to establish influencer relations as a distinct function (per Borchers & Enke, 2021), while establishing normative guidelines in what largely has been an unregulated relationship field for public relations and influencers (Archer & Harrigan, 2016). Given that the potential for influencers to “achieve PR objectives seems neither fully explored nor exploited” (Borchers & Enke, 2021, p. 10), this study seeks to answer the call to determine how to integrate influencers in public relations. The following research questions guided this study. One question examines meanings and motives, the other, strategy and tactics.

RQ 1: How do professionals conceptualize influencer relations?

RQ 2: How do professionals manage influencer relations?

### 3. Materials and methods

To understand how professionals navigate influencer relations, this study employed qualitative in-depth interviews with 14 communication professionals who work with influencers. Qualitative methods allowed us to investigate meaning making on an in-depth scale (Hammarberg et al., 2016).

#### 3.1. Data sampling

We employed criterion sampling, which involves selecting participants according to certain criteria (Lindlof & Taylor, 2019). In this case, a participant was deemed qualified for this study if she or he had served as the liaison between the company and the influencer for at least one campaign. In our sample, all participants worked with influencers on an ongoing basis as part of their role. When recruiting practitioners who worked directly with influencers, some worked in public relations while others worked in marketing. Additionally, interviewing individuals from both sides of the aisle allowed us to identify a broad set of influencer management procedures, consistent with theoretical sampling, which requires recruiting participants who can speak to as many categorical concepts as possible (Glaser & Strauss, 1967). Concepts included influencers, influencer relations, influencer marketing, influencer campaigns, strategies, tactics, protocols, and best practices.

We also sought to get a range of types of professionals from specialists to managers, with the limitation that we had to rely on convenience sampling through recruiting from the authors’ professional networks. Nevertheless, we believe we reached a good degree of conceptual saturation—themes across interviews were generally consistent and no new themes began to emerge in our final three interviews (Glaser & Strauss, 1967).

This sampling method yielded a total of 14 interviewees, which is valid for a qualitative study because qualitative methods consider the depth of understanding more important than the sample size (McCracken, 1993). In sum, we interviewed eight females and six males,

**Table 1**  
Participant Information.

| Participant | Gender | Ethnicity | Job Title                                               | Company Type              |
|-------------|--------|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| 1           | M      | White     | Global Digital Marketing Leader                         | Restaurant                |
| 2           | M      | White     | Marketing Director                                      | Software                  |
| 3           | F      | Indian    | Head of Employee Advocacy                               | Software                  |
| 4           | M      | White     | Senior Influence Strategist                             | Marketing and Advertising |
| 5           | F      | Indian    | Vice President, Influencer Marketing and Communications | Software                  |
| 6           | M      | Latino    | Global Head of Social Marketing                         | Digital Startup           |
| 7           | F      | White     | Manager, Brand & Social Marketing                       | Retail                    |
| 8           | F      | White     | Vice President, Influencer Marketing                    | Agency                    |
| 9           | M      | White     | Director of Content Marketing                           | eCommerce                 |
| 10          | F      | Latina    | Marketing Specialist                                    | Health and Beauty         |
| 11          | M      | White     | Owner of Agency                                         | Social Media Marketing    |
| 12          | F      | White     | Entrepreneur                                            | Marketing                 |
| 13          | F      | White     | Media Relations and Influencer Marketing                | Agency                    |
| 14          | F      | White     | Sr. PR and Communications Manager                       | Crafting Company          |

and participants in this study worked for a variety of organization types and sizes. De-identified participant information can be found [Table 1](#).

3.2. Data collection

We used a semi-structured interview guide based on the two research questions. Sample interview questions included: “How do you determine which influencers to work with?” “How do you work with influencers?” and “How do you build relationships with influencers?” The interview guide can be found in [Appendix A](#). In-depth interviews lasted between 45 and 60 min and were conducted on Zoom. Interviews were recorded and transcribed verbatim.

3.3. Data analysis

Following data transcription, interviews were analyzed using a grounded approach to coding whereby we used open coding and a constant comparative method to identify concepts ([Charmaz, 2006](#); [Corbin & Strauss, 2008](#)). We began with in vivo coding in which we used the actual words and ideas from interviews to identify themes ([Lindlof & Taylor, 2019](#)). In this process, each transcript was analyzed for added depth from other transcripts before compiling the list of themes ([Corbin & Strauss, 2008](#)). Following this first round of open coding, the emergent themes were used as categories, and these categories were re-evaluated throughout the process. As such, we synthesized the theoretical categories as we sought to piece together the story, examining how.

the categories related and seeking to identify meaning underlying the process, consistent with qualitative coding ([Charmaz, 2006](#)). We also compared themes to concepts in the literature regarding influencers and relationship management. The coding list can be found in [Table 2](#).

To establish inter subjective reliability, all researchers coded one interview and then discussed themes to arrive at a consensus. After we gained consensus, one researcher coded the remaining interviews. All authors reviewed and agreed on the final codes.

3.4. Validity

The validity of this study can be assessed through [Kvale’s \(1995\)](#) concepts of validity. First, craftsmanship validity was achieved through an open-ended interview guide that allowed participants to discuss topics on their own terms. Communicative validity was achieved through the conversational nature of the interview. Pragmatic validity was reflected in the ways the principles we identified had been proven through practice, as reported by interviewees.

4. Results

Participants discussed a range of both influencer marketing and influencer relations-oriented topics. All filled roles in influencer relations and most filled roles in both areas, with most discussing the

overlapping nature of the roles. For our purposes, we focused interviews on discussing the purposes, values, and practices to get a broad set of perspectives on working with influencers. Many participants specifically differentiated their work in influencer relations from other related functions (esp. marketing), as reported below. We also asked participants to discuss the differences of influencer relations from other functions. This analysis identifies the themes related to influencer relations that emerged from discussions, purposes of influencer relations, differentiating the function from others, and building relationships for sustained value.

4.1. RQ 1: How do professionals conceptualize influencer relations?

4.1.1. Credibility

At the heart of influencer relations was credibility. Participant 9 said influencers were “someone to vouch for us” in an industry where “we don’t have a lot of credibility.” Similarly, Participant 7 worked with influencers who “have credibility within a space” and who could “humanize the brand.”

Influencers granted organizations an authentic voice. Participant 3 summarized, “I’m not necessarily swayed by followers, you want to see that they’re authentic. Audience does not equal influence.” Participant 8 worked with influencers because they “bring stories that feel real.” She explained: “Gone are the days that you can work with a celebrity to do this fake endorsement. The consumer is too smart.”

The value of influencer credibility was also evident in instances when participants use influencers as advisors in their industry. Participant 14 explained that she often invited influencers to tradeshow, to employee meetings, and even to speak with journalists because of their ability to speak to the latest trends in the industry. She explained, “One of the things we look for is media-ability—are they able to serve as a pseudo-spokesperson for the brand? Influencers are leveraged in our PR activities.” Overall, then, influencer relations was about gaining the credibility and authenticity an influencer provided as a “real person” above and beyond sponsored advertising on social media.

4.1.2. Networked reach

Influencer relations was about distributing messages through networks. For example, Participant 2 referenced a popular variant of the six degrees of separation: “How do you talk in terms of the Kevin Bacon game? How do you try to figure out what is that second degree opportunity?” Participant 7 said, “We’re looking to connect with the community, not just put a face to what we’re doing.”

Though many admitted the need to get “all the eyeballs you can on a post” (Participant 6) and “bring volume to the table (Participant 2), the dominant sentiment was that the “Kardashian business model is waning” (Participant 2). The search for influencers with millions of followers is giving way to prioritizing influencers with smaller but committed networks. These influencers with niche audiences gave professionals “access to people we may not necessarily have access to” (Participant 3). Participant 4 added, “their audience hangs on their every word and will follow their instructions.” In this way, then, professionals sought to reach specific, even niche, publics through a trustable source by working with influencers.

4.1.3. Friends with benefits

Influencer relations granted participants certain relationship benefits. One was the ability to substitute payment with the value of the connection. Participant 2 said, “The notion of influencer relations is what’s old is new again. It’s how do we have a relationship that we can try to put to work for us without being overtly paid.” Participant 5 said, “Influencers feel like they’re contributing to something right, and they’re creating a relationship with you. So, you’ll do things in those relationships that aren’t always paid. It’s a two-way beneficial relationship.” Participants also said building relationships minimized the need to find new influencers for every campaign, creating efficiency

Table 2  
Coding List.

| RQ1: Concepts     | RQ 1: Purposes | RQ 2: Strategies  | RQ 2: Tactics    |
|-------------------|----------------|-------------------|------------------|
| Vs Celebrities    | Branding       | Relationship      | True to Self     |
| # of Followers    | Credibility    | Short v Long term | Grant control    |
| Popularity        | Enter a Market | Trust             | Networking       |
| Blurry Definition | Product        | Commitment        | Openness         |
| Levels            | Exposure       | Satisfaction      | Shared Interest  |
| Amplifier         | Goodwill       | Power             | Work w/Mediator  |
| Niche             | Analytics      | Community         | Internal Support |
| Expert            | Authenticity   | Paid              | Social Media     |
| Risk              | Create Content | Unpaid            | Listening        |
| A Relationship    |                | Mutual Benefit    |                  |
| PR or Marketing   |                | Organic           |                  |



because, as Participant 11 said, influencers are so busy it can be “very difficult to connect with influencers quickly.”

This relationship component differentiated influencer relations from advertising. Participant 6 said, “The reason I love social is the concept of building relationships. Most people do social wrong because they are just using the channel as an ad channel.” Many said building relationships was “doing social media right.” To this end, participants often worked to make influencers partners, rather than advertising outlets. Participant 14 said influencer partnerships shield her company against the risk of the influencer doing something to damage the company’s reputation. Similarly, Participant 2 said relationships helped her company “stay away from those pitfalls where you’re engaging with someone who really would not speak highly of you” (Participant 2). In sum, relationship benefits included promotion beyond paid arrangements, risk minimization, and the efficiency of working with the same influencer on multiple campaigns.

#### 4.1.4. Measurable results

Metrics were a motivator for influencer relations. Participant 2 explained, “It’s a little art and a little science. There’s a lot of analytics.” The difficulty was determining what metrics mattered. Most discussed quantity metrics like impressions, shares and likes. Others prioritized quality metrics like audience relevance. Participant 2 said, “Some could have a million followers, but only a handful of them are actually relevant to you. And so falling in love with the quantity metric can be a bit of fool’s gold.”

Though the nature of social media made results relatively easy to gather, Participant 8, said, “You can’t guarantee results.” Participant 2 said, “Depending on your market and the influencer set, you have to pick your horses. Once you pick, not everyone can win the race, and so hopefully you pick the right horse, and it puts you in a good place.” So, practitioners worked with influencers for the possibility of increasing measurable metrics with strategic publics.

#### 4.1.5. Differentiating influencer relations

Participants contrasted influencer relations with a few other roles because influencer relations did not “fit neatly in any box” (Participant 2). First was media relations, in which participants differentiated influencers from media personnel based on the tendency to pay influencers. Participant 6 said, “It gets really blurry because you have all these pay-to-play opportunities.” Participant 7 said, “It’s an interesting gray area. Media are starting to develop social followings and become influencers themselves.”

Second, participants contrasted influencer relations with influencer marketing and content marketing. For Participant 5, influencer relations was building relationships, but influencer marketing was “doing things like demand gen, lead gen programs, advocacy programs, deep funnel, mid funnel activities.” Participant 14 said influencer marketing was managing influencer content to drive sales, but influencer relations was building the relationship with the company.

The relationship focus of influencer relations put the function “in the PR bucket” (Participant 5) because it yielded “the same metrics as PR” (Participant 2). Participant 4 said influencer relations dealt with “the public relations angle” because it entailed “getting people to act or think differently about a topic or issue.” Participant 12 connected influencer relations to public relations because she saw it as the “management of relationships between the organization and its influencers.” Participant 14 connected influencer relations to public relations because of the emphasis on working with SMIs to tell “good brand stories as a whole.”

Participants also said influencer relations went hand-in-hand with other related functions, especially influencer marketing, with many signaling integration between public relations and marketing when working with influencers. In fact, some participants filled both influencer marketing and relations roles. Participant 13 summarized the phenomenon in this way:

Influencer marketing and influencer relations are in the same bubble.

Influencer relations is the act of contracting the influencer, building rapport, and building relationships. Influencer marketing is posting content and measuring results. Influencer relations is the process and influencer marketing is the results. You can’t do one without the other.

Therefore, influencer relations was considered an integrated public relations function with influencer marketing. The distinction was influencer relations’ focus on building long-term relationships to support marketing’s promotion management.

### 4.2. RQ 2: How do professionals manage influencer relations?

#### 4.2.1. Outreach and selection

Though some used managers and agencies to find influencers, outreach and selection were handled personally by the practitioner. Participant 5 said, “I really caution people from working with agencies to do influencer outreach because influencers really want the relationship with the brand.” To this point, participants often reached out to influencers directly, like Participant 6 who used “shout-outs” to test interest from influencers. “We would retweet them and given them a mention. This was part of our relationship building, like Hey, we’re listening.”

Selecting potential influencers to work with involved finding an authentic voice, filling niche interests, and rewarding those who had shown their loyalty to the company. Recruiting influencers who were already fans of the brand was common. Participant 3 said good candidates are those who have “checked off all the boxes. The quality of their work is stellar. They have a tremendous influence. They’re a good cultural fit.” Participant 8 said, “We want real people who our consumers can relate to. We don’t want these glossy people who you look at and you’re like, ‘I can’t see myself in that person.’”

Organizational fit was also important. Participant 3 explained, “What I really do is the cultural vetting. Are they a good fit? Do they represent our values?” Perhaps for this reason, some admitted selecting influencers who were already talking about the brand. Participant 1 said, “We are always looking at it from those two different points: people who talked about us and are known to like us, and people who we think could probably be fans.” Niche interests were a common focus, as Participant 2 said, “I don’t believe influencer relations is a one-size fits all activity... Nuance is important because not every influencer is going to be able to do all the things that you may want.” Many also echoed Participant 13 who built a list of trusted influencers she could turn to. Overall, influencer relations involved personal outreach and selection based on fit and potential to reach niche publics.

#### 4.2.2. Building a tribe

Even though many agreed with Participant 1, who said, “You don’t want to pigeon yourself into only working with people who talk about you,” participants had a set of trusted influencers they worked with. Most only branched out if there was a need, like Participant 3 who said, “If the skill set isn’t available within the cohort of folks that we have, then we’ll reach out.” As such, participants either worked within a community of influencers or created their own.

Many participants built their own influencer communities. Participant 3 said her group of influencers felt “part of a larger tribe” because they had “such an allegiance to one another. They talk about it as a family, which is so heartwarming.” Participant 1 compared his community to the Marvel Cinematic Universe. Participant 2 said this type of structure made it “relatively easy” because he had “relationships across multiple influencers.” Building an influencer community allowed Participant 2 to “pair people up and know that it’s going to work.” Many hosted regular check-ins with SMIs and showed them special attention, with many getting access to company executives. Participant 6 said executives at her company gave SMIs “the red-carpet treatment” and the chance to “go behind the scenes to look at the roadmap.”

Working within influencer communities was also common. In fact, some considered it necessary because, “[Influencers] talk to each other.

They gossip like the rest of us. It's a tight community, and you want to be seen as a valuable member to that community" (Participant 5). Participant 7 said that her brand, a major shoe store, was "really focused on leveraging the communities" so that her efforts were "homegrown" and were "empowering to the people that are within that culture." Her goal was to be "authentic and stay honest to who those people are."

As influencers gave participants access to their communities, participants returned the favor with access to other clients. Participant 1 said the key was to not be "stingy with your brand contacts" because "it's compound interest after a while." In fact, Participant 8 said influencers were so excited by the potential for building their network that "many didn't even talk about compensation." Overall, working with influencer communities enabled participants to work with SMIs more fluidly and provided SMIs added value beyond payment.

#### 4.2.3. Building relationships

In nearly every case, professionals sought long-term, mutually beneficial relationships with influencers, which often meant engaging them on a personal level. Participant 2 summarized, "Influencer relations is taking that long game, getting to know the person, allowing that person to get to know you. How you meet their needs and wants puts you in a place to find those areas of mutual benefit." Building relationships required setting up expectations early, or as Participant 10 said, "I prefer to work with influencers who are interested in building up relationships and expectations over time. Regardless of how quickly either party would like to engage, it is important to make sure each party has a good understanding of the other."

The long-term relationship was often a personal endeavor. Participant 14 said she followed influencers with her personal accounts to "try and get to know them like a friend." She continued, "We've never looked at it as a transactional relationship. We want it to feel authentic, and it's worth putting in time and effort to maintain the relationship."

Mutual benefit was the imperative in relationship building because it ensured that SMIs were "more thoughtful because it's more important to them" (Participant 7). Participant 3 summarized mutual benefit: "What can we do to leverage our brand and [what can] our influence do to help build yours?" As such, influencer benefit was often defined as granting the influencer promotional opportunities. Participant 3 said, "I'm helping connect the dots, making introductions and getting them as many gigs as possible." Participant 5 explained, "Sometimes it is exposure, right? They're getting awareness in front of a new audience." Participant 4 said, "If you're advocating for the influencer then that actually creates stronger, better relationships with the influencers over time, and you get better cooperation."

Many described testing the relationship early with non-monetary benefits first. For example, Participant 3 said "Of course, I'm gonna go to the people that have scratched my back, right? Like, it's just human nature." Participant 14 said, "We start small first," and then they ramped up activities if things went well. Participant 6 said, "Part of the best practice here is to make sure you have this kind of loyal allegiance to you as a human being." Participant 1, summarized, "I firmly believe whether it's this industry or its life, you will get what you put in."

Openness was a common imperative. Participant 14 said, "Most problems start as communication problems" and that success in influencer relations is "having open conversations and treating these individuals as a member of your team." Participant 3 explained that building a relationship allowed her to have the "tough conversations." She said, "There are gonna be times when the person that started out as a good fit. You think it's gonna work, and then at a certain point it doesn't. And so being able to have those conversations. Having to say, 'Hey, the quality of your work has now all of a sudden, deteriorated.'" Participant 7 said, "You have to have an honest relationship with them to be able to say, 'Hey, this is why it's going to help you. This is why it's going to help me.'" Openness required listening because "you find what they care about and you can position yourself into the conversation that's gonna sound interesting to them" (Participant 6). Participant 8 explained, "I

think [listening] helps me be better at my job."

For many, the goal was to build a partnership with influencers. Participant 4 explained, "I don't want to pay you any amount of money for a handful of posts. What I want to do is partner with us so that I can be a value to you over time. And, therefore, you can also be a value to me." Participant 13 explained the value of an ongoing partnership: "We go back to the same influencers because our audience will get to know that influencer's face and know that they're a partner of the brand." This partnership also involved bringing influencers in as consultants to advise the company on trends and best practices.

This relationship focus tied influencer relations to public relations. Participant 7 said, "Just like public relations, you're not going to get any publicity without the relationship. To perform, the relationship is the requirement, and the better the relationship is going to make the better performance." Participant 2 said long-term investment in the relation was "where the magic happens," but it was also "harder than the short game" because the return on investment was difficult to track. Overall, selecting the right SMIs and building mutually beneficial relationships was central to influencer relations.

#### 4.2.4. Transactional vs. organic

Interviews revealed a division between the short-term, transaction-based approach and long-term, organic influencer relations. The transactional model comprised paying influencers for content without promise for future work. Participant 2 called this advertising-based approach "the hired gun model" because it involved going "straight to the bottom line [to figure out] who can we pay to do something for us?" Transaction-based activities were an easy sell to executives because of the immediate publicity, but Participant 7 said that transaction-only activities "don't really amplify anything." Participant 6 called this transaction focus the bottle rocket model:

"We light off all these different bottle rockets, and they're cool for five seconds. And then they disappear and then you're like, 'We're out of bottle rockets. Now what do we do?' For me, it's about building a bonfire because a bonfire is like a beacon in the night that people come and gather around and share stories and it warms you. I always tell my team, 'It's great to have bottle rockets, but point them at the bonfire. Let's keep stoking the fire.'"

Many admitted that influencers are not looking for a one-and-done transaction because "that's not a relationship" (Participant 7). Transaction-based interactions also did not shield against "the person saying your product is good one day and it's substandard the next" (Participant 2). For this reason, Participant 3 tried "to stay away from the pitfalls" of working with an influencer who "is not going to advocate for you outside of a paid relationship" because "you're engaging with someone who really would not speak highly of you outside of some sort of paid relationship." Participant 5 warned, "If it's purely transactional, that's how the content will come out" and Participant 8 advised, "If it feels transactional, the consumer is hyper aware that it feels like an ad."

Instead, participants preferred "authentic and organic relationships without a campaign being attached to them" (Participant 7). The organic approach resembled a retainer-model in which participants reached out to influencers on a regular basis with both paid and unpaid opportunities. Participant 3 described the organic model in this way, "If we have an online event and we say, 'You amplify this,' I'm not saying five grand per tweet. That's just all organic." The value of an organic approach is that "it doesn't feel like I'm just using [the influencer]" (Participant 7). Participant 2 explained that the organic model "pays dividends because that's when influencers want to work with you, where influencers just amplify something because they are in tune with you and following you." In short, organic interaction meant that SMIs "amplify [your content] even though they're not being paid because there's some other value in it for them" (Participant 5).

This is not to say that the organic approach was unpaid and non-contractual. Rather, the organic approach reflected a mindset that the

relationship was ongoing, and contracts and payments were used for specific activities. Participant 1 referred to these activities as “activations” to connote the idea that the SMI was a long-term partner that would be paid for specific work. Monetary compensation was critical in that arrangement because, as Participant 7 said, “There’s only so many times you can pay someone with the product.” Participant 5 warned:

“No one should work for free, so be careful what you’re asking from someone. If influencers feel you’re just taking from them, and they’re not really getting a lot out of it, that’s when the relationship goes south.”

Participants often preached the need to be cautious because “you don’t want to take advantage of people” (Participant 7). For Participant 13, monetary compensation was about equality: “Recent years we’ve talked about diversity, and how creators of color might undervalue their rates. By not paying influencers or not stating rates up front, you’re perpetuating the paying of influencers of color less than white influencers.” In this way, compensation was a necessary part of working with SMIs in both transactional and organic approaches.

Overall, organic relationships appeared to be the favored approach to working with influencers for its long-term orientation and capacity to build mutually beneficial relationships that went beyond a contractual agreement. However, that did not preclude using a transactional approach as well. In fact, some reported using both approaches at the same time in an integrated structure that produced synergy through the benefits of a paid activation and the benefits of an ongoing relationship.

#### 4.2.5. Balancing control and creative freedom

Participants wanted to ensure that influencer activities were on message, but they also wanted to give influencers the freedom to create independently. Participant 1 explained it this way: “A lot of companies will give marching orders to creators. We give more guardrails to allow the space and freedom to help build that creative.” Participant 3 called the tendency to give influencers marching orders “It’s such sleazy, slimy, used car salesman behavior.” Participant 9 said giving influencers too much direction was “clipping their wings” because “it doesn’t feel like their stuff. It feels like an ad.” Participant 6 warned that restricting influencers would lead the influencer to respond, “We’re not your marketing machine.”

Participants said ceding some control meant that influencer content felt “natural” and “real”. Rather than dictating direction, many suggested talking points. “It’s not ‘blast this out,’ it’s ‘Should you think this is valuable to your audience, here’s some assets for you to use,’” Participant 3 said. Participant 9 said being “really hands off lets them know that they are valued” and “trusted” rather than “micromanaged.” Participant 3 advised, “Do not micromanage them. Give them enough to understand how the company does things but get out of their way.”

Successful influencer relations hinged on collaboration. Participant 6 explained, “You’re thinking about them versus just giving orders. I don’t like a relationship where you’re just an order taker or an order giver. In the collaborative effort, you come up with something you hadn’t thought of that can be even more engaging for the audience.” Participant 2 summarized, “It boils down to the need to feel relevant and wanted.”

Of course, this did not mean leaving all content decisions up to the influencer. Many used agreements to set up expectations and ensure quality. Participant 13 even recommended “sticking to your guns” when an influencer’s content isn’t up to the client’s quality. She admitted, “Sometimes you have to be the bouncer. If you’re getting to a point where they’re unhappy, chances are they won’t want to work with you again anyway.” Overall, then, practitioners walked the line between granting control to influencers and stifling them with demands through listening and collaboration.

## 5. Discussion

This study’s results provide context for defining influencer relations

and differentiating it from other functions, including influencer marketing and media relations. Responses show that influencer relations focuses on influencer selection, relationship development, and mutual benefit that may go beyond an influencer’s social media posts and campaign involvement. From this study’s results, we propose the following definition for influencer relations:

*Influencer relations is the strategic communication function that initiates and develops mutually beneficial relationships with influencers for long-term benefit and community impact for both influencer and organization.*

Influencer relations is responsible for 1) identifying influencers with good brand or organizational fit, 2) building mutually beneficial relationships, 3) working with and through influencer communities, and 3) identifying influencers who may become strategic partners 3) to build long term value for both influencer and organization. Whereas influencer marketing integrates influencers into brand communication (Bakker, 2018), influencer relations integrates influencers as partners for mutual-benefit. Both are needed to work with influencers successfully. Results show that influencer relations works in tandem with influencer marketing to ensure relationship satisfaction and long-term value.

In this integrated system, influencer relations works within the sphere of public relations (Gallagher, 2021) as a tool for long-term impact in the form of mutually beneficial relationships for organization and influencer, while influencer marketing manages the paid endorsement of influencer content (Hudders et al., 2021). Though influencer relations may work in the details of the relationship, the function goes beyond the management of contracts, content, and analytics (which may be reserved for marketing) to focus on ensuring the success of the ongoing relationship between organization and influencer. As such, public relations principles of dialogic communication, ethical interaction, and relationship building apply. This, in turn, helps ensure consistency for both an organization’s publics and an influencer’s followers. The following sections outline standards for influencer relations theory and practice and differentiate the function from influencer marketing.

### 5.1. Managing influencer relations

This study reveals relationship practices that may be distinct because of the influencer context (consistent with claims by Borchers & Enke, 2021). These include community building, balancing risk and control, strategizing compensation, and monitoring ethics.

Practitioners initiate and develop long-term relationships through communities, whether they work through influencer communities or build their own. Networking is critical in this endeavor. Early on, Hon and Grunig (1999) argued for the importance of networking through the networks of an organization’s publics, and this study shows the preeminence of networking through influencer communities. This community orientation keeps influencers loyal to the organization, even yielding benefit beyond a paid contract (i.e. word-of-mouth, unpaid influencer promotion). These findings support previous scholarship on the influencer’s function as an intermediary between organizations and online communities where they lend the organization both access and credibility (Jacobson & Harrison, 2022; Lou, 2022).

This community-orientation was also inherent in discussions regarding the difference between transactional and organic influencer work. Rather than focus on a short-term, transaction-based advertising orientation (Borchers & Enke, 2021) in which practitioners have “regressed from relationship builders to marketers and advertisers” (Wolf & Archer, 2018, p. 497), the organic approach emphasizes community networking in which practitioners work through and grant advantages to those in their own influencer communities.

Influencer relations also appear to be marked by balancing the risk of granting influencers creative freedom and the need to maintain control over messaging, a tension that has been discussed before (Borchers & Enke, 2021; Childers et al., 2019; Davies & Hobbs, 2020; Haenlein et al.,

2020; Leung et al., 2022; McMullan et al., 2021). This study suggests that the benefits of granting influencers creative freedom, including credibility, authenticity, and relationship satisfaction, outweigh the risks to organizational reputation.

Furthermore, relationships act as a shield against negative word-of-mouth behaviors, suggesting that ceding control should be weighed against relationship quality. These findings are consistent with studies that have shown a relationship's protective and risk-reducing qualities (Seltzer & Lee, 2018; Smith et al., 2021). Risk is essential for building effective organization-public relationships (Kent & Taylor, 2016). This study's results confirm that risk is both necessary and mitigated by the quality of the influencer-organization relationship.

Effective risk management may also hinge on dialogic communication. Mutual benefit and relationship satisfaction were evident when practitioners valued influencer perspectives, ceded control, and communicated transparently, consistent with dialogic communication principles (Kent & Taylor, 2016). This finding provides some reassurance that practitioners are not just "plundering the space for profit" (Archer, 2019, p. 160) because dialogic partnerships provide long-term beyond the profit value of a short-term transactional agreement. It may also be the case that influencers increasingly expect high levels of transparency, creative freedom, and satisfaction based on what they have seen in fellow influencers' experiences. In this way, the need for a balanced relationship may drive practice, a conclusion that is especially important given the tendency for practitioners to take a pragmatic approach (rather than a normative one) to navigate influencer relationships (Archer & Harrigan, 2016).

Compensation adds another layer to the uniqueness of influencer relations. Not only does it integrate quality of content into the relationship, but it renders practitioners as content reviewers. Compensation may be considered foreign in other public relations activities, but negotiating contracts is increasingly a standard that applies across both marketing and public relations work with influencers. This study grants context to Davies and Hobbs (2020) assertion that paid partnership should be connected to long-term relationship building: payment is one factor of relationship satisfaction. Furthermore, compensation does not necessarily reduce the influencer to a paid corporate sponsor (a fear reported by Davies & Hobbs, 2020), but rather calls on practitioners to understand and work through influencer credibility and authenticity.

Of course, given the overlapping nature of working with influencers evident in interviews, it is likely that the above concepts may also exist or relate to influencer marketing. However, the distinction between the two falls on the influencer relationship. While influencer marketing deals mostly with the production of sponsored influencer content, influencer relations emphasizes relationship satisfaction for ongoing or future endeavors. While influencer marketing may emphasize product fit, audience reach, and sponsored content creation (Vangelov, 2019; Ye et al., 2021), influencer relations emphasize community, mutual benefit, and a long-term relationship based on shared interest, open communication, and involving influencer input into organizational activities (Brunton & Galloway, 2016; Kent & Taylor, 2016; Smith, 2012). The two orientations are not antithetical, but synergistic—and demonstrate the integrated nature of working with influencers.

## 5.2. Integrated influencers

This study's results show that public relations, marketing, and advertising work together in influencer communication. This boundary between functions may be blurry, which may be why practitioners said influencer relations did not fit neatly within any functional box. Influencer relations may require reaching across the aisle and working seamlessly in an overlapping set of responsibilities. For example, the same influencer may work with influencer marketing on content review and with influencer relations on training employees in social media trends.

This influencer-led integration reflects claims from previous studies

that social media roles may engender the integration of marketing and public relations (Smith & Place, 2013). This study's results, then, suggest that influencer communication is integrated, and responsibilities are distributed across marketing and public relations because influencers cross traditional marketing and public relations boundaries. Borchers and Enke (2021) argue that the centralizing function is strategic influencer communication, which oversees influencer relations and influencer marketing. Future studies should examine the integrated structure of working with influencers.

## 5.3. The relations in influencer relations: relationships in theory

This study's results suggest that the influencer-organization relationship works because of the mutual benefit underlying the interaction, consistent with the theory of relationship management (Ledingham, 2003). This mutual benefit is derived from several critical relationship factors. First is the concept of control mutuality, or the agreement of control (Grunig & Huang, 2000). In the influencer-organization relationship, control mutuality revolves around granting influencers control over creating content. The relationship is transparent as practitioners provide influencer some guidance and then "get out of their way," as one participant said.

Listening is imperative in successful influencer relationships. This study's results reinforce claims that an influencer should be treated as "an active and empowered social media user who is *listened to* and seen as a trusted source" (Agostino et al., 2019; Hudders et al., 2021, p. 333, italics added). Listening yields trust and is also a critical component of ethical influencer interaction. There is a modest but growing focus on listening in ethical public relations (see Moon & Yang, 2021; Neill & Bowen, 2021) and in influencer research. The concept of reciprocity in Borchers and Enke (2022) may relate to listening—it hinges on influencer and practitioner recognizing each other's contributions and "seeing other actors with their individual motivations" (p. 6). Therefore, as a reciprocal activity, listening is an active process of both being attentive to influencer needs and recognizing influencer value.

Successful influencer relations also appear to hinge on relationship satisfaction. This is consistent with research showing that relationship satisfaction influences willingness to voice support for an organization (Lee, 2019). Relationship satisfaction is also dependent on sense of belonging (Pang et al., 2016), which was achieved in this study through building influencer communities. Openness is also a factor of relationship satisfaction (Ferguson, 2018), a principle reaffirmed by this study's finding that being transparent and flexible led to effective influencer relations. Finally, this study demonstrates the value of communal relationships above exchange relationships. Communal relationships, which differentiate public relations from marketing (Ki & Hon, 2007), require going beyond transactional arrangements to support stakeholder welfare (Hon & Grunig, 1999). Findings in this study show that effective influencer relations was based on the practitioner's efforts to go beyond paid arrangements and support influencer efforts to develop their reputation and grow their career. Influencer relationships may begin through exchange, but, ultimately, effective influencer relations depend on a communal orientation.

## 5.4. Best practices in influencer relations: practical implications

This study suggests best practices for influencer relations. *First, successful influencer relations is based on playing the long-game.* While there is value in the one-and-done, hired gun model, practitioners should also work toward long-term influencer partnerships. This effort begins with identifying potential influencer partners based on interest overlap. Doing so allows the influencer to remain authentic to her or his audience and enables the practitioner to credibly reach highly relevant publics. In this endeavor, interest overlap may take priority over number of followers.

*Second, influencers should engage in active listening.* Hallmarks of active



listening are respect, transparency, and an orientation toward influencer benefit. Manipulation and exploitation should be avoided. Active listening should be coupled with regular check-ins with influencers, as this study shows.

*Third, practitioners must grant creative freedom to influencers.* Influencer success hinges on authenticity (Borchers & Enke, 2021), rendering control over content creation an imperative. This means practitioners must be willing to engage in risk, but with risk comes reward, including reciprocity and idea exchange (Sisson, 2017). Furthermore, this study shows that dialogic communication practices and providing loose guidelines mitigate risk. Mutually-beneficial relationships are a shield against an influencer “going rogue,” whereas a transactional relationship offers no such protection once the transaction is complete.

Of course, granting creative freedom does not mean stepping out of content production entirely. Rather, practitioners may serve as sounding boards or even as partners in the creation process. This balance of control and working in partnerships is one way that influencer relations is more than simply a “transfer of routines from traditional communication functions to influencer communication” (Borchers & Enke, 2021, p. 12).

*Finally, influencer relations is a personal endeavor.* The influencer relationship is more an influencer-practitioner relationship than it is an influencer-organization one. Success in this study came by treating influencers as friends rather than as media outlets. Influencer relations, then, should build no-strings-attached and beyond-the-transaction connections based on common interest and personal care.

### 5.5. Limitations and future research

This study’s results may have been affected by a couple of factors, the principle of which was the predominance of marketing professionals and perspectives from the technology industry. This was not just on account of our convenience sampling method. Influencer relations was not a common title. Instead, those who worked with influencers directly were often from influencer marketing. However, participants also commonly worked in tandem across both marketing and public relations. We mitigated this potential influencer marketing focus to talk about influencer relations-oriented practices. The extent to which the findings reflect public relations principles validates the relevance of this study’s findings to public relations.

Additionally, we did not distinguish between for-profit or non-profit organizations as this division was not a focus of this study. Still, differences in relationship activities with influencers between for-profit and non-profit organizations are likely, and future research should examine these differences.

## 6. Conclusion

This study suggests that influencer relations is an integrated strategic communication function that relies on mutually beneficial relationships and community involvement. Relationships mitigate the risk of working with influencers and should be developed from a personal orientation. This relational orientation yields productive influencer activities that transcend what a transactional approach may produce.

### Conflicts of interest

We have no known conflicts of interest.

### Data Availability

Data will be made available on request.

## Appendix A. Influencer Relations Interview Guide

### Ice Breakers

1. Tell me about your job. What types of things do you do?
2. How did you get into this type of work?
3. What is the favorite part about what you do?
4. What challenges have you faced in your position?

### Research Questions

*RQ 1: How do professionals conceptualize influencer relations? .*

1. Tell me, how do you define an influencer?
2. How do you differentiate an influencer from other similar types of people (i.e. opinion leader, celebrity)?
3. What role do influencers play in your organization?
4. Why do you work with influencers?
5. How do you involve influencers in your work?
6. How do you determine which influencers to work with?
7. What terms does your company use to refer to working with influencers?
  - a. What is the difference between terms (if any)?
  - b. What do you think about the term influencer relations?
  - c. What does influencer relations mean to you?
  - d. How is influencer relations different from other functions?
8. What are the key characteristics of influencer relations?
  - a. What does the concept mean to you?
  - b. What do you think it means to your organization?

*RQ 2: How do professionals manage influencer relations?*

1. Can you describe the process of working with influencers?
  - a. What are your main job responsibilities in this area?
  - b. What do you enjoy about influencer relations?
  - c. What difficulties do you face in influencer relations?
2. How often do you engage in paid influencer relations?
  - a. What are the purposes?
  - b. What are the benefits?
  - c. What are the drawbacks?
3. How often do you engage in unpaid influencer relations?
  - a. What are the purposes?
  - b. What are the benefits?
  - c. What are the drawbacks?
  - d. Which do you prefer? Paid or unpaid? Why?
4. How do you build relationships w/influencers?
  - a. For what purposes do you build relationships?
  - b. What are the benefits of building relationships?
  - c. What are the drawbacks?
  - d. Can you describe the process of building relationships with influencers?
  - e. What works and doesn’t work?
5. How would you characterize the relationships you build with influencers?
  - a. How do you manage expectations?
  - b. How do you build trust?
  - c. How do you build commitment?
  - d. How do you ensure influencers are satisfied?
  - e. How do you negotiate compensation? What role does compensation play in the relationship?
  - f. How do you negotiate power or influence between the influencer and what your organization wants?
6. What challenges have you faced when working with influencers?
  - a. Why do you think you faced those challenges?
  - b. How have you managed those challenges?
  - c. What would you do differently?

7. What do you think are the best practices of influencer relations?
8. What are the most important practices to avoid when working influencer relations?

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